

AZ.3 Inspection Sequence & Clocks

The clocks that run against a city permit counter and not a county one, the two authorizations on the septic system, the certificate of occupancy you may never get, and a log.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. Arizona adopts no statewide residential building code — every code that binds a house is adopted locally, by ordinance, and the edition on your permit is whatever your city or county's adopting ordinance says it is. What is **not** local: a county building permit is required by statute for any construction over \$1,000, and inside a city the city's own permit ordinance governs; the owner-builder exemption, the signed statement you file with every permit application, the septic general permit and the well rules are all state law and apply whether or not anyone will ever inspect the framing. The unit is the **jurisdiction** — a city inside a county routinely differs from the county around it, and the city has statutory permit clocks the county does not. Confirm every item with the office that will actually handle your parcel before you rely on it. No Arizona statute names a residential building inspection; the sequence is IRC R109 as your ordinance adopted it. What the statutes do fix — and fix differently for a city and a county — is how long the counter may take and what happens when it takes longer. Read your column.

THE CITY/COUNTY ASYMMETRY — READ YOUR COLUMN

Both the city and the county "regulatory bill of rights" articles define "license" to include "the whole or part of any ... permit, certificate, approval, registration, charter or similar form of permission required by law" (A.R.S. § 9-831(3); § 11-1601(4)). Then the county version takes the house back out:

Arizona Revised Statutes § 11-1605(M), verbatim

"This section does not apply to a license that is either: 1. Issued within seven working days after receipt of the initial application or a permit that expires within twenty-one working days after issuance. **2. Necessary for the construction or development of a residential lot, including swimming pools, hardscape and property walls, subdivisions or master planned community.**"

The city version exempts only the seven-day and twenty-one-day permits (§ 9-835(O)). So every clock, the one-request rule, the refund and the mid-build bar below apply to a **city** house permit, and none of them applies to a **county** one. Any table that shows counties reviewing faster than cities has this backwards.

One house, two regimes

	City permit	County permit
Review time frame	Posted on the city's website — an overall time frame, split into administrative completeness and substantive review (§ 9-835(A), (B))	None. Ask in writing under § 11-1609 what the county's practice is, knowing it is not enforceable by refund
Corrections	"one comprehensive written or electronic request for corrections" ((G))	As many as the county wants
Denial	Not for a residential application unless the city notified you within 15 working days of submission that it may be denied for "excessive substantive deficiencies" ((G))	No statutory limit
Refund	Automatic if the city exceeds its time frame or its one request ((K))	None
Mid-build plan changes	Barred while you build to the approved plan ((N))	No statutory bar
Inspections	IRC R109 as adopted; no statutory clock	"at the earliest reasonable time" (§ 11-863(B)) — the only county clock on a house
What both owe you	The counter handout; no unauthorized conditions; a written clarification within 30 days (§§ 9-834, 9-836, 9-839)	The same three (§§ 11-1604, 11-1606, 11-1609)

If speed matters and you have a choice of lots, this table is the reason to prefer one inside city limits. If you are in a county, the § 11-1609 letter — a written answer within thirty days — is the only clock you can start yourself, and AZ.5 has the template.

THE CITY CLOCK — A.R.S. § 9-835, RULE BY RULE

What a city permit counter owes you, and what it costs the city to miss

Rule	The text	Cite
Posted time frames	A city "shall have in place an overall time frame during which the municipality will either grant or deny each type of license," stating separately "the administrative completeness review time frame and the substantive review time frame," posted on its website	A.R.S. § 9-835(A), (B)
Completeness	Notice of completeness or of "a comprehensive list of the specific deficiencies" within the completeness time frame; if none issues, "the application is deemed administratively complete." The clock suspends until the missing information arrives	§ 9-835(D)–(F)

What a city permit counter owes you, and what it costs the city to miss

Rule	The text	Cite
One request for corrections	"During the substantive review time frame, a municipality may make one comprehensive written or electronic request for corrections," amendable once to add missed legal requirements "and the legal authority for the requirements"; supplemental requests "limited to issues previously identified." "Within ten working days after a request by the applicant, the municipality shall meet or discuss with the applicant the request for corrections"	§ 9-835(G)
The residential no-denial rule	"a municipality may not deny a residential license application that is necessary for land development or building construction unless the municipality considers the application withdrawn or the municipality has notified the applicant and the property owner within fifteen working days after the submission of the application that the application may be subject to denial because of excessive substantive deficiencies"	§ 9-835(G)
Extension; denial contents	Extension only by mutual written agreement, not more than 50% of the overall time frame. A denial must state its statutory, ordinance or code justification, the appeal route with the number of working days to protest, and the resubmittal fee	§ 9-835(I), (J)
The automatic refund	If a city "makes more than one comprehensive ... request for corrections and one supplemental ... request ... to a license application necessary for residential building construction ... or does not issue ... within the overall time frame," it "shall refund to the applicant all fees charged for reviewing and acting on the application." It "shall not require an applicant to submit an application for a refund," must pay within thirty working days, and the refund "may not be waived by an applicant"	§ 9-835(K)
Resubmittal fees	After a denial, nothing beyond "the cost of processing the resubmitted revisions or corrections"; after a withdrawal, not more than 50% of the original unrefunded fee	§ 9-835(L), (M)
No mid-build changes	A city "may not modify, rescind or request any subsequent modifications or revisions to an approved plan or permit for residential land development or residential building construction during construction if the construction is done in accordance with the approved plan or permit" — unless a field condition unknown at review, your own request, or a code noncompliance the city had not already ruled on	§ 9-835(N)

What a city permit counter owes you, and what it costs the city to miss

Rule	The text	Cite
Waiver; enforcement	"A municipality shall not request or initiate discussions with a person about waiving that person's rights." Private civil action; the court "may award reasonable attorney fees, damages and all fees associated with the license application"	A.R.S. § 9-834(D), (E)

A.R.S. § 9-470.01 — fifteen working days, then a third-party reviewer (cities of 30,000 or more)

"If a municipality with a population of thirty thousand persons or more does not approve, conditionally approve or respond with required additions or revisions to an application for a single-family residential building permit **within fifteen working days after the date the application is submitted**, any required review of the application may be performed by a qualified third party selected by the municipality ... A municipality shall maintain a list of at least three third-party reviewers." The city "may not request or require an applicant to waive a deadline" ((C)); you may appeal any decision ((D)); you pay the third party's fees to the city ((F)); hillside ordinances and federal floodplain reviews are outside it ((G)); the building official's power to withhold a certificate of occupancy is untouched ((H)).

The catch, verbatim: "The time frame prescribed by this subsection does not begin until the applicant has satisfied the following requirements: 1. The municipality has approved construction documents for the dwelling to be constructed. 2. The municipality has approved vertical construction activities to begin ... on the individual lot." Read with the definition in (I), the fifteen days for a one-off custom house appear to attach to the steps *after* the construction documents are approved — permit issuance — not to the plan review itself. That is this kit's reading, not the statute's words; confirm it with your city in writing before you count on a fifteen-day plan review.

WHAT A COUNTY STILL OWES YOU

The county rules that survive the carve-out

	The statute	Cite
No unauthorized conditions	A county "shall not base a licensing decision in whole or in part on a licensing requirement or condition that is not specifically authorized by statute, rule, ordinance or code," and prints the section on every application	A.R.S. § 11-1604(A), (H)
The handout	At application: the list of steps, the time frames, a contact, the website, and notice of the clarification right	A.R.S. § 11-1606

The county rules that survive the carve-out

	The statute	Cite
Clarification in 30 days	A written request — name, address, the provision, the facts, your proposed interpretation, whether it is pending on an application — draws "a written explanation of its interpretation or application" within thirty days	A.R.S. § 11-1609
Inspections	County inspection rules "shall require that such inspections be made at the earliest reasonable time." Fees: "reasonable" — no state schedule	A.R.S. § 11-863(B), (C)
Alternatives and interpretations	Every county code "shall contain a provision for an advisory board consisting of at least five members" — an architect, an engineer, a licensed general contractor, a member of the public and a tradesperson — "to determine the suitability of alternative materials and construction and to permit interpretations." In a city, every denial must name the appeal route (§ 9-835(J)(2))	A.R.S. § 11-862(A)

THE BUILDING INSPECTIONS — IRC R109 AS YOUR ORDINANCE ADOPTED IT

Nothing in Title 9 or Title 11 names an inspection. The sequence is the model code's — foundation, rough plumbing, mechanical and electrical, frame, final — as amended locally, and the local lists read for this kit look like it: Graham County's is setback, footing, framing, rough electrical, mechanical and plumbing, drywall and final. Cochise Option 1 requires "only limited Building Code inspections dealing with the trade areas of Mechanical, Electrical, Plumbing and Fire Prevention," requested "at least twenty-four (24) hours in advance" (OBA Secs. 5, 15). **Ask for the jurisdiction's own list** — the § 9-836 / § 11-1606 handout should carry it — and write it on the log.

The inspection-rights statute does not cover the inspections you book. A.R.S. § 9-833 "Does not apply to a municipal inspection that is requested and scheduled by the regulated person" ((N)(2)) — which every routine building inspection is. This kit does not cite it as a right.

Where nobody inspects the wiring — ask the utility before you frame

In Greenlee County the engineer's letter says the county "does not inspect construction." Under Cochise Option 2 there are "no building code inspections." Coconino's AMMP page says the program yields no utility "green tag." What APS, SRP, TEP, UniSource or your cooperative requires before it will set a meter on an uninspected house is in that utility's own service-requirements manual, which this kit did not read. **Get the utility's clearance rule in writing before framing**, and write it on the record in AZ.2. The Cochise amendment is candid about the alternative: no dwelling built under it "shall be required to be connected to a source of electrical power, or wired" (Sec. 21).

THE CERTIFICATE OF OCCUPANCY — AND THE THREE PLACES IT NEVER COMES

No Arizona statute requires a certificate of occupancy for a single-family dwelling; the requirement is the locally adopted IRC R110 as amended. State law mentions the CO twice: as a reporting event to the assessor and the Department of Revenue (A.R.S. § 9-467(A); § 11-321(G)), and as one of the two starts of the one-year no-sale clock — "completion or issuance of a certificate of occupancy" (§ 32-1121(A)(5)). Greenlee County issues none. Cochise Option 2 yields none and Option 1 a "conditioned" one (OBA Sec. 16). The Coconino AMMP yields none. **In those programs it cannot be obtained later**, a lender or buyer will ask for it, and the only start date for the one-year clock is "completion" — so write down the day the house was finished, with a photograph, and keep every inspection record you do have.

SEPTIC AND WELL — THE CLOCKS THAT ARE THE SAME EVERYWHERE

ADEQ, your delegated county, and ADWR

	The rule	Cite
Construction Authorization	No construction before it issues; "A person shall complete construction within two years of receiving a Construction Authorization" or the Notice of Intent expires. Changes that still conform need no re-approval but go on the site plan	A.A.C. R18-9-A301(D)
Discharge Authorization	On the Request for Discharge Authorization, with the final site plan and the tank watertightness certification; the county "may inspect the facility before issuing." Book the before-backfill inspection with the county — do not cover a trench on your own schedule	A.A.C. R18-9-A301(D); A309(C)
ADEQ's posted review clock	On the Notice of Intent form itself: 42 business days administrative + 31 substantive = 73 overall for a single 4.02 permit; each alternative-setback request "adds eight business days." A delegated county's clock is the county's — and a county residential permit sits outside § 11-1605	ADEQ DWS 402, rev. April 2025 (R18-1-525)
Transfer inspection — if you sell	"Within six months before the date of property transfer, the person who is transferring a property served by an on-site wastewater treatment facility shall retain an inspector to perform a transfer of ownership inspection" — an ADEQ-qualified engineer, sanitarian, septage hauler, ROC-licensed septic contractor or certified operator. The tank must have been pumped unless the facility "was put into service within 12 months before"; no inspection if it was never put into service. The buyer files a Notice of Transfer within 15 calendar days	A.A.C. R18-9-A316

ADEQ, your delegated county, and ADWR

	The rule	Cite
Well — drilling card	Within 15 days of a complete notice ADWR mails the drilling card to the driller; "The well shall be completed within one year after the date of the notice"	A.R.S. § 45-596(D), (E)
Well — reports	The driller's report within 30 days of completion; your completion report within 30 days after the pump is installed	A.R.S. § 45-600

Permit life is local. The only verified figure in the state is Cochise's: 36 months, one 12-month extension on written request with substantial progress (OBA Sec. 12). Ask for yours and write it on the AZ.2 record. An owner-builder who sells inside the one-year window is selling a house with a septic system under a year old, and R18-9-A316(C)(2)(a) is written for exactly that case.

INSPECTION LOG — RECORD EVERY REQUEST AND EVERY VISIT

Every visit, whoever required it — and the date you asked, which is the only clock a county recognizes

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	Septic site investigation — by the registered engineer, geologist, sanitarian or certified investigator (name): Investigator _____ Done _____ Report _____		
☐	Zoning setback, then footing / foundation — the § 11-815(B) sketch on file; footing if a code is enforced on my permit. Asked _____ Done _____ Result _____		
☐	Septic before backfill — the county's inspection; tank watertightness certified. Asked _____ Done _____ Result _____		
☐	Rough plumbing, mechanical, electrical — Cochise Option 1 inspects these only; 24 hours' notice. Asked _____ Done _____ Result _____		
☐	Frame, then drywall / insulation where the local list has it — and the energy method my ordinance requires, if any. Asked _____ Done _____ Result _____		

Every visit, whoever required it — and the date you asked, which is the only clock a county recognizes

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	Utility clearance — what the power company needed, and the date the meter was set. Requirement _____ Meter set _____		
☐	Septic Discharge Authorization received — no discharge before this. Asked _____ DA issued _____		
☐	Well — drilling card at the site; completion; driller's report; my completion report within 30 days of the pump. Card _____ Done _____ Driller's rpt _____ Mine _____		
☐	Final , and the certificate of occupancy if one issues where I am building — or the dated, photographed record of completion if none will. Final _____ CO no. _____ Completion _____		
☐	Any inspection my jurisdiction requires that is not on this list — ask, and write it here: Inspection _____ Date _____		

Everything cited here is free to read. Statutes are at **azleg.gov**, one section per page (azleg.gov/ars/32/01121.htm — title unpadded, section padded to five digits). Rules are the Arizona Administrative Code, one PDF per chapter at **apps.azsos.gov** and reproduced section by section at law.cornell.edu/regulations/arizona. **One warning:** the Registrar of Contractors licenses contractors, not owners, and it is not your building department — the city or county is. Read September 2026.